

Jay Stewart

Product Engineer · Available now for remote contract work · UK citizen, UK-registered sole trader

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Profile

Product engineer who finds out what users need, then ships it the same day with coding agents. Since March 2026 I have built and run SpiralClass, a live payments platform, and launched WantToJoin, which went from a user-research finding to a pilot at a hostel within three days. Before that I spent eight years on e-commerce backends, on systems that hold other people's money. Available for contract work with early-stage startups: MVPs, first versions and product engineering.

Experience

Founder & Product Engineer, Independent · Mar 2026 – present

WantToJoin (wanttojoin.com): one page per hostel with tonight's plans, RSVPs and a live meeting pin, piloting at one hostel.

- Read 2,800 messages from five months of a hostel's guest WhatsApp group before writing code. The finding changed the product: the hostel's social hosts are the customer, not the guests.
- Reviewed the competition (Hostelworld Linkups, SocialStay) and built only what they don't offer: no app to download, a live pin, and pooling across independent hostels.
- Got the hostel to agree to a one-week trial and shipped features from what its hosts actually did: several hosts at once, a host view in Spanish, phone reminders, and the plan kept separate from what actually happened.
- 129 commits in three days on Cloudflare Workers and D1, with PostHog analytics. Every user-facing change is tested in a real browser at phone width.
- Each experiment has a written hypothesis and kill criteria before any code. The second experiment is booking with deposits for cash-only local tour operators.

SpiralClass (spiralclass.com): scheduling, payments and video for independent teachers, built and run solo, live with real teachers and students.

- TypeScript end to end: Next.js 15, Postgres through Prisma (82 models), Inngest background jobs, self-hosted LiveKit video.
- Moved payments to Stripe Connect direct charges on Accounts v2, so the teacher is merchant of record. Added Wise as a second payment rail, reconciled through its API.
- Release engineering: a merge gate tied to the exact commit pushed, the same definition of green locally and in CI, coverage floors, migration drift checks and a documented database rollback.
- Cut CI spend by tracing about 744 billable minutes a month to one workflow, without making any step manual.
- Built largely with coding agents. The agent isn't accountable and I am, so every change goes through a pull request and a gate.

Career break · Mar 2020 – Mar 2026

A planned break after eight years in e-commerce, travelling on savings. Building again since March 2026.

Backend Engineer, G&V | Venture Brands Agency (contract) · Bristol · Jul 2017 – Mar 2020

- High-traffic e-commerce platforms, including Dyson's store. Custom backend modules for stores handling transactions and customer data at scale.
- Fixed production issues where an outage meant lost orders, working with client engineering teams against fixed launch dates.

Backend Engineer, Thrive Chiropractic (contract, remote) · Aug 2016 – Mar 2020

- Designed and built a booking and payment platform from scratch, and ran it for four years: real-time scheduling, secure payments, and the reporting the practice used to make decisions.

Backend Engineer, Folk Digital · Bournemouth · Jul 2014 – Aug 2016

- Backend features and third-party integrations for performance-sensitive e-commerce clients.

Backend Engineer, C3 Media · Bristol · Jul 2012 – Jul 2014

- Went from junior PHP developer to building and maintaining full e-commerce systems on my own.

How I work

- **I start with users.** I talk to them in person, read their real conversations, and change the plan when the evidence points somewhere else.
- **Experiments have a stopping rule.** A hypothesis, what gets built, what gets measured and when to kill it are all written down before the code.
- **Agents write a lot of the code, and I own the result.** I do the verification: pull requests, CI gates and testing in a real browser, so the result doesn't depend on a reviewer happening to notice a problem.

Skills

- **Product:** user interviews, analysing chat and usage data, competitor research, experiment design, pilots with real customers
- **Building with agents:** Claude Code, parallel agent sessions in git worktrees, CLAUDE.md conventions, CI gates and browser testing to verify agent output
- **Stack:** TypeScript, Node, Next.js, Postgres, Prisma, Cloudflare Workers and D1, Inngest, LiveKit; PHP and Magento before 2020
- **Payments:** Stripe Connect (direct charges, Accounts v2), Wise, Mercado Pago
- **Operations:** GitHub Actions, Sentry, PostHog, release and rollback processes
- **Languages:** English (native), Spanish (working)